

Style Guide Audit

Last updated Mar 27, 2025 | FINAL

Purpose: Evaluate and refresh the style guide to ensure it aligns with changes to the brand voice. Prepare the information to move from the [Writing at Upwork](#) site to the Supernova platform.

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Style and format

Body copy

When we're consistent in our writing style, it helps us build trust with the people who interact with Upwork every day. It helps them see that we're one company, no matter which internal team wrote the thing they're reading.

This guide covers the basics that are specific to Upwork. If your case isn't covered, use [AP style](#).

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Abbreviations

It's okay to use most standard American abbreviations, including acronyms (within reason), shortened words, and contractions.

For acronyms, spell out the full term on first use, followed by the abbreviation in parentheses. After that, you can use the acronym on its own.

Periods with abbreviations

We don't use periods in many abbreviations, especially in measurements, time units, states, and well-known acronyms. Refer to AP style for a full list.

✓ Do this:

Job time: 20 min

Monica is based in New York, NY.

The CEO presented the company's growth strategy during the annual meeting.

✗ Not this:

Job time: 20 min.

She works out of Washington, D.C.

The C.E.O. presented the company's growth strategy during the annual meeting.

One important exception is to use periods for the abbreviation of the United States.

✓ Do this:

This freelancer lives in the U.S.

✗ Not this:

This company is looking for US-based freelancers.

File types and extensions

Use all caps for abbreviations of file types.

✓ Do this:

You can upload JPEG, GIF, or PNG files.

✗ Not this:

You can upload .jpeg, .gif, or .png files.

Plural abbreviations

Don't add an apostrophe before the s when you form the plural of an abbreviation, unless it's possessive.

Product names

Don't abbreviate any Upwork product names, unless the abbreviation or acronym is commonly known and used. [View approved product names](#)

Days and months

Months and days of the week can be abbreviated where appropriate with no periods. Don't use all caps.

Do this:

Jan
Tue
Mon

Not this:

JAN
Tues.
MON

Addresses

U.S. addresses

For U.S. addresses, put the recipient on the first line, the company (if needed) on the second line, the street address on the third line, and then the city/state/postal code on the fourth line.

Use a comma between the city and state, and include one space between the state and postal code. Use "postal code" not "ZIP code."

Do this:

Jose Longoria

Upwork
525 W Van Buren St STE 1100
Chicago, IL 60607
USA

U.S. states

Use AP Style two-letter abbreviation for U.S. state names, such as CA for California.

International addresses

Many international addresses put the postal code and the city name on the same line. Put the recipient on the first line, the company (if needed) in the second line, the street address on the third line, the postal code and the city on the fourth line (which one comes first varies by country), and then the country on the fifth line. Include one space between the postal code and the city name.

The format of international addresses varies by country. Use the [Universal Postal Union guidelines](#) when you format international addresses for specific countries.

 Do this:

Guillaume Debois
Accenture
5 Notre Dame
13888 Paris
France

Capitalization

There are 3 styles of capitalization:

- **Title case** capitalizes the first letter of every word except articles, prepositions, and conjunctions. This Is Written in Title Case.
- **Sentence case** capitalizes the first word of each sentence and any proper nouns. This is written in sentence case.
- **Uppercase** capitalizes every letter. THIS IS WRITTEN IN UPPERCASE.

Here's how we use them at Upwork. (For specific names of products and features, [go to the word list](#).)

Title case

In general, avoid using title case because:

- It's [harder to process](#)
- It's [slower to read](#) because it uses fewer lowercase letters
- It quickly becomes inconsistent—it's tricky to decide which words to capitalize

Title case should only be used in these cases:

- Article, blog post, ebook, and success story titles in the Resource Center and blog (subheadings remain in sentence case)

- Press releases
- YouTube video titles

If you need to use it, here's a helpful [text converter](#). Use the AP style filter.

Sentence case

We almost always use sentence case. This includes for:

- Headings
- Buttons
- Page titles
- Clickable links
- Menus
- Tooltips

You'll need to capitalize the names of brands, companies, software, products, and services — these things are proper nouns.

If you're not sure what needs to be capitalized, check our [word list](#) or send a message to #ask-content-design on Slack.

✅ Do this:

Your job feed
View profile
Try Business Plus
Go to settings

❌ Not this:

Your Job Feed
View Profile
Try business plus
Go to Settings

Uppercase (All caps)

Avoid using all capital letters unless the word is an acronym. It's hard to read and can come across as screaming.

Exception: "New" and "Beta" tags, which are written in all caps.

Clause order

Put conditional clauses before instructions, not after them. Try to mention the circumstance before you provide the instructions, so readers can skip the instruction if the condition doesn't apply.

 Do this:

To learn more, see the user guide.

If you have questions, visit our support guide.

Now that your first proposal is submitted, are you wondering what's next?

 Not this:

See the user guide to learn more.

Visit our support guide if you have questions.

Are you wondering what's next now that your proposal is submitted?

Contractions

Since we want to sound informal and conversational, it's okay to use contractions when they make a sentence easier to understand.

You can use common contractions of be verbs (also known as state-of-being verbs) and auxiliary verbs with not, as well as common contractions of be verbs and auxiliary verbs with personal pronouns.

 Do this:

aren't

isn't

can't

couldn't

didn't

doesn't

hadn't

haven't

weren't

won't

he's

I'm

I've

it's

she'll

they're

we've

you're

here's

let's

that's

there's
what's

Nouns and contractions

Avoid contractions that combine a proper noun or regular noun with a verb.

Do this:

Uma will help you draft a proposal.

Upwork is going to make a big announcement next quarter.

Not this:

Uma'll help you draft a proposal.

Upwork's going to make a big announcement next quarter.

Countries and cities

Use the English version of international countries and cities.

Do this:

Sweden

Germany

Venice

Not this:

Sverige

Deutschland

Venetia

Lists

Use numbers if there are steps the user needs to take in order. Otherwise, use bullets. List items should not end with periods, unless the item includes multiple sentences. In that case, punctuate normally.

Here are two examples:

Numbers

Here's how to send a proposal:

1. Pick a job
2. Bid your price
3. Set a start date
4. Add the number of hours
5. Send in your proposal

Bullets

To bid for a job, you need your:

- Bid amount
- Start date
- Estimate of time it will take to finish

Quotes

Always cite the source of a quote or statistic. This includes the author's last name, year of publication, and page number (if applicable). When citing web pages, use the author and date if known.

For example:

A recent report said "more than 40% of workers would be willing to work from home if it meant more time with their family" (Thomas, 2015, 244)

Long quotes

If you need to use a long quotation, set off the quotation from the other text using a smaller font, with one space before and after the quote. You can also include a pull quote that includes part of the quotation.

URLs

Don't use the "www" designation (it's obvious by now) and don't include the "http://" path. Sub-domains follow these same rules.

✓ **Do this:**

upwork.com
mail.google.com

✗ **Not this:**

http://www.upwork.com
<http://mail.google.com>

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Numbers, dates, and currency

Body copy

Basics

Use numerals instead of spelling numbers out. (Exception: for content on the Resource Center and blog, spell out numbers below 10 and use numerals for numbers 10 and above.)

Use a hyphen (-) when indicating a range, and don't put spaces before or after.

✓ **Do this:**

July 18-20

✗ **Not this:**

July 18 - 20

Use a comma with numbers of 4 digits or more.

✓ **Do this:**

2,045

✗ **Not this:**

2045

Don't use K for thousands.

✓ **Do this:**

15,000

✗ **Not this:**

15K

Currency

Use the U.S. dollar for the standard currency. When referring to dollars, use USD instead of U.S. Dollar. For foreign currencies, add the [currency abbreviation](#) (ISO 4217) after the amount.

✓ **Do this:**

15.50 GBP

✗ **Not this:**

15.50 pounds

Spell out million, billion, and other large numbers.

✓ **Do this:**

15 million

✗ **Not this:**

15,000,000

Don't use fractional monetary units like cents.

✓ **Do this:**

\$0.13

✗ **Not this:**

13¢

Don't use spaces with numbers and units.

✓ **Do this:**

\$15/hr

✗ **Not this:**

\$15 / hr

Dates

Use full dates with a comma after the day when you have the space. Don't add zeroes to days.

✓ **Do this:**

December 3, 2026

✗ **Not this:**

Dec 03 2026

Abbreviations

If you need to shorten the date, use three-letter month abbreviations without periods. Don't use shortened formats like MM/DD/YYYY—it doesn't work internationally.

✓ **Do this:**

Dec 3, 2026

✗ **Not this:**

12/03/2026

Jan. 01, 2025

Ordinal numbers

If you're including a month, don't add an ordinal (e.g. *th*, *rd*, *nd*).

If you're *not* including a month, you can include the ordinal. Write it in normal text, not subscript.

✓ **Do this:**

This job starts on December 2.

This job starts on the 12th.

✗ **Not this:**

This job starts on December 2nd.

This job starts on the 12th.

Date ranges

Separate a range of dates with a hyphen and no spaces before and after. Show the year at both the start and end, unless both dates are in the same year.

✓ **Do this:**

December 3, 2025-January 3, 2026

December 3-10, 2025

✗ **Not this:**

December 3, 2025 - January 3, 2026

December 3 - 10, 2025

Days of the week

Try not to shorten the days of the week, but if you have to, use *Mon*, *Tue*, *Wed*, *Thu*, *Fri*, *Sat*, and *Sun*.

Times

Use numbers, except noon or midnight. If it's on the hour, you don't need to include the minutes (unless it looks inconsistent with other times you're talking about). We use the 12-hour clock (not 24-hour) and we use am or pm with a space.

✓ **Do this:**

2:30 pm

4 am

✗ **Not this:**

2:30 PM

03:00 p.m.

Cumulative minutes, hours, elapsed time, and rates

If you're talking about cumulated time (like how long a freelancer has worked on a project), use decimals without adding zeroes, and use "min" and "hr" to save space. When it comes to elapsed time (like timesheets), use a colon between the hours and minutes.

✓ **Do this:**

3.25 hr

12:31 hr

60 min meeting

✗ **Not this:**

03.25 hours

12:31 hours

60 min. meeting

For rates, don't add any spaces.

✓ **Do this:**

\$95/hr

✗ **Not this:**

\$95 / hr

Time ranges

Separate a range of times with a hyphen and no spaces. Use one lowercase am or pm, and no leading zero.

✓ **Do this:**

2-4 pm

✗ **Not this:**

02:00 - 04:00PM

Time zones

Include the user's [time zone](#) if it provides helpful context, like when they're scheduling a meeting.

Spell out the time zone when you have space. If not, abbreviate it in all capital letters without periods.

✓ **Do this:**

4 pm Australian Eastern Time

9 am AET

✗ Not this:

04:00 pacific time

9:00 am pt

If the time zone doesn't have a name, use the offset from Coordinated Universal Time (UTC).

Don't include spaces around the plus sign (+) or hyphen (-).

✓ Do this:

UTC+7

UTC-2

✗ Not this:

4:00 UTC -2

utc+4

Relative time

When possible, include the relevant time and date when something happened.

✓ Do this:

You hired Chetan on Dec 3, 2016.

✗ Not this:

You hired Chetan on 852 days ago

Writing dates and times together

Write the date, then the time and time zone. Use "at" to separate them. If it's less than a week away, you can include the day of the week to provide helpful information for the user.

✓ Do this:

October 20, 2019 at 10:23 am PT

You have until Friday, February 17, 2023 at 12:30 pm Eastern Standard Time to dispute these charges.

✗ Not this:

Oct 20, 2019 10:23 am PT

You have until February 17, 2023 on Friday, 12:30 pm to dispute these charges.

It's OK to abbreviate the day of the week and the month. But don't mix your abbreviations. If you're shortening one, shorten both.

✓ Do this:

Your consultation with Haley is on Monday, January 12, 2022 at 1 pm Eastern Standard Time.

Available on Mon, Jan 12, 2022 at 1 pm ET.

 **Not this:**

Your consultation with Haley is on Monday, Jan 12, 2022 at 1 pm Pacific Daylight Time.

Measurements

When you're talking about distance, temperature, volume, size, weight, or any other kind of measurement, use numerals (even if it's under 10).

You can abbreviate measurements, such as KB and GHz, if the abbreviations are well known. If not, spell out the unit in full.

When using a unit of measurement, put a space between the number and unit.

 **Do this:**

128 GB

 **Not this:**

128GB

Phone numbers

International

For international numbers, or to write U.S. or Canadian numbers for international audiences, add the abbreviation of the country and a plus sign (+) immediately before the country code.

 **Do this:**

US +1 4155551212

 **Not this:**

+1 4155551212

Local audiences

Then you don't need the country code. For example, if you are writing for a North American audience, put the area code in parentheses followed by a space, and then enter a hyphen after the three-digit exchange code.

 **Do this:**

(415) 555-1212

 **Not this:**

415-555-1212

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Ampersands

Don't use an ampersand (&) unless it's:

- Part of a company or brand name
- Creative use in a headline
- Part of *current* ontology and structured data practices for category names

Use "and" since it's easier to read and will help us localize internationally in the future. Some people with lower literacy levels also find ampersands harder to understand.

✓ **Do this:**

Time and payments

Ben & Jerry's

✗ **Not this:**

Time & payments

Ben and Jerry's

Apostrophes

Use the curved apostrophe ('), the same character as a single closing quotation mark.

Plurals

Don't use apostrophes for plurals of single letters, symbols, mathematical signs, or acronyms.

✓ **Do this:**

FAQs

✗ **Not this:**

FAQ's

Possessives

For singular nouns, use an apostrophe followed by an “s”, including proper nouns ending in an “s” or “z” sound. For plural nouns, add an apostrophe, but no s.

 Do this:

The CEO's announcement

Use the writers' guide

 Not this:

The CEOs announcement

Use the writers's guide

Don't use our product names as possessives—rewrite the sentence instead.

 Do this:

Business Plus makes it easy to find and hire freelancers.

 Not this:

Business Plus' features make it easy to find and hire freelancers.

Colons

Use colons to keep sentences flowing and introduce lists. When you use a colon in a sentence, the first word after it should be lowercase. For example:

Time to get started: let's create your account.

If the text preceding a colon is bold, make the colon bold as well.

Commas

Use commas to separate items in a series, and to separate certain kinds of clauses. Use the serial comma to separate items in a list, and place commas (and other punctuation) inside quotes.

 Do this:

Work on websites, apps, and other technology.

The prototype "works," but not very well.

 Not this:

Work on websites, apps and other technology.

The prototype "works", but not very well.

Ellipses

Use ellipses (...) when you want to indicate an unfinished thought or sentence. They work well for loading states. For example:

Setting up your account...

Em dashes

To show a break or a change of direction in the middle of a sentence, use the em dash (—) with spaces before or after it. Here's an example.

See all your apps — work and social — in one place.

Exclamation points

Be careful about using exclamation points. Ideally, we want the content of what we're writing to excite our users, not the punctuation itself.

Too many exclamation points can come off as over-excited or self-centered, when we want to come off as focused on our users and what they need.

Hyphens

Use hyphens to compound adjectives or for ranges. Don't use spaces on either side.

✓ Do this:

High-quality talent

Enter your email address.

You'll be working on this project full time.

✗ Not this:

High quality talent

Enter your e-mail address.

You'll be working on this project full-time.

Parentheses

Periods in parentheses

If there is a sentence inside parentheses, the period at the end also goes inside the parentheses. In all other cases, the period goes outside the parentheses. For parentheses that

appear in the middle of sentences, don't add periods, even if the text in the parentheses is a standalone sentence.

 Do this:

Contact us. (We typically respond in 24 hours or less.)

 Not this:

Contact us. (We typically respond in 24 hours or less).

Question marks and exclamation points

Place question marks or exclamation marks inside parentheses only when they're part of the parenthetical text.

Periods

End full sentences with periods, unless it's a question, and only leave one space between sentences. This includes things like form field descriptions.

Acronyms and abbreviations

Don't use periods with most acronyms or abbreviations, such as MB, PhD, or EPA. Generally, it's better to spell out abbreviations.

Decimal points

Use periods to represent decimal points.

Headings, headlines, and titles

Don't use periods in headings, headlines, or titles. This includes things like form field labels.

In quotes

In general, put a period inside a quote if it ends a sentence, even if the period isn't part of the text inside the quotation marks. If the text inside quotation marks ends with a question mark or exclamation point, don't use a period.

Links

If a link is part of a full sentence, include a period at the end. Make sure the link formatting does not include the period (the underline should stop before the period).

For stand-alone links (e.g., "Show more"), don't use a period.

Slashes

Try not to use slashes. Exceptions include computer files and URLs: then it's fine. If you're writing out a Windows path, use backslashes (\).

 **Do this:**

These instructions are for PC and Mac users.

 **Not this:**

These instructions are for PC/Mac users.

Trademarks

Use the trademark symbol [superscript TM] on the first instance only or with the most prominent use of the mark. The remaining instances should be without the symbol. Always use the full trademarked name and proper capitalization. You can find a list [here](#).